South Asia, as well as in the wider Bay of Bengal and Indian Ocean regions.

By portraying various facets of Indian culture as pluralist and benign, New Delhi's soft power strategy seeks to emphasise India's distinctiveness over China, and, at the same time, it also seeks to reassure smaller neighbours by appealing to shared religious, social, political, and economic values. These alleged unique selling points are diplomatically expressed as four different cultures of pluralism. While not targeting China specifically, they present India as a more appropriate, reliable, and sustainable partner for countries in South and Southeast Asia. As Nicolas Blarel emphasises, "by publicising the pluralist nature of its politics and society, India intends to prove it is a cooperating, stabilising and exemplary rising power, in contrast to China's more aggressive, if not neo-colonial model."[2]

This chapter reviews India's soft power approach as a response to the change in balance of power with China and the South Asian neighbourhood. It begins by reviewing the drivers of India's new strategy, including the rising power asymmetry with China and conversely the Indian decline as South Asia's predominant power. The second section proceeds to review how Indian leaders and officials have defined soft power as a geostrategic objective, often in relation to China and other smaller neighbours, and the specific role of public diplomacy. The third section focuses on the four pluralist components of this new strategy, all seeking to portray India as a benign partner in implicit contrast to China. The final section concludes with a discussion of the limitations of India's soft power strategy, including lack of resources, domestic challenges, limited appeal, and Chinese competition.